

British Board of Coaching (BBC)

Free Resource – Starter Guide

The Foundational Coaching Guide

Introduction to Professional Coaching

Professional coaching is a transformative partnership between coach and client, built on trust, active listening, and powerful questioning. This guide introduces the core principles, ethical boundaries, and essential frameworks that every coach must master before working with clients.

Core Coaching Competencies

The International Coach Federation (ICF) defines eleven core competencies grouped into four clusters: setting the foundation, co-creating the relationship, communicating effectively, and facilitating learning and results.

- Active Listening: Fully concentrating on what the client is saying and not saying.
- Powerful Questioning: Asking open-ended questions that evoke discovery and insight.
- Direct Communication: Clear, articulate expression during coaching sessions.
- Creating Awareness: Helping the client identify patterns and gain fresh perspectives.
- Designing Actions: Co-creating opportunities for ongoing learning during the session.

Ethical Guidelines & Boundaries

Coaches must maintain clear ethical boundaries at all times. This includes confidentiality, avoiding conflicts of interest, recognizing the limits of coaching versus therapy, and referring clients to other professionals when appropriate.

- Maintain strict confidentiality of all client information.
- Clearly define the coaching relationship in a written agreement.
- Recognize when a client needs therapy or medical intervention and refer accordingly.
- Avoid dual relationships that could impair professional judgment.

Essential Conversation Frameworks

The GROW model (Goal, Reality, Options, Will) is the most widely used coaching conversation framework. It provides a structured yet flexible approach for guiding clients from identifying their goals to committing to action.

- Goal: What does the client want to achieve?

- Reality: What is the current situation?
- Options: What choices are available?
- Will: What will the client commit to doing?

Structuring Your First Session

The first coaching session sets the tone for the entire engagement. Begin by establishing rapport, reviewing the coaching agreement, exploring the client's goals, and agreeing on the working relationship. End with clear action steps and a confirmed next session.

